The Rite of the Stūpa

Stūpavidhi · Toh 1259 · Derge Tengyur

མཆོད་རྟེན་གྱི་ཆོ་ག

The Rite of the Stūpa, known in Sanskrit as the Stūpavidhi and in Tibetan as Mchod rten gyi cho ga, is Toh 1259 in the Tengyur, where it belongs among the commentaries and ritual works on the tantras. It is a brief ritual manual for practitioners of the Hevajra tantra on making small clay stūpas for the benefit of oneself and others. It describes how the yogin, visualizing himself as his deity, purifies the clay into emptiness, generates it as Hevajra in union with his consort, stamps the stūpas with mantras, imagines each one radiating countless Hevajras, and finally consecrates them with the verse of dependent arising. Its colophon attributes it to the great master Kṛṣṇapāda and records that it was translated into Tibetan by the monk Nyima Gyaltsen Palzangpo at the temple of Tharpa Ling.

In the language of India: stūpa bidhi nāma. In the language of Tibet: The Rite of the Stūpa.

Homage to Hevajra.

If a yogin of Hevajra wishes to make stūpas for the sake of himself and others, he should first make clay from earth together with precious substances, scented water and the like, and place it before himself. He should make himself vividly present as his chosen deity and meditate on the four immeasurables. Then, with the mantra of the purity of the nature of reality, oṃ svabhābiśuddha sarva dharmā svabhāva śuddho'haṃ, he meditates on the clay as without any object of reference, and by way of the three rites makes it into the form of Hevajra, father and mother.

Then, with light rays from the hrīḥ or the hūṃ at his heart, he summons all the buddhas and bodhisattvas. Hevajra, father and mother in union, melts into light and becomes the awakening mind; this is blessed with the heart mantra of Hevajra twenty-one times, and then one should stamp the stūpas with these mantras: oṃ depa bicu vajra hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ svāhā, or else oṃ āḥ hrī hūṃ.

One imagines each stūpa as a Hevajra, and from each of these, in turn, many Hevajras radiate; and one imagines that through this activity the aims of oneself and others are fulfilled. Then one should consecrate them with the heart mantra of dependent arising and conclude.

The Rite of the Stūpa, composed by the great master Kṛṣṇapāda, is complete. Having heard it from the great grammarian Excellent Fame of the Victor, the translator, the Śākya monk Nyima Gyaltsen Palzangpo, translated it well at the great temple of glorious Tharpa Ling.

Translator's Notes

• The great grammarian's name, Tibetan □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, could not be identified with confidence and is translated by its meaning; it may render an Indian name such as Jinakīrtibhadra. "The three rites" refers to the threefold method of generating a deity, and "the heart mantra of dependent arising" is the well-known verse on dependent arising used in consecrations.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.